

Practice Paper 33 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Parents “leaning forward”

1 mark — The narrator senses that the audience is preparing themselves to **applaud politely** whatever happens, i.e. they are not expecting brilliance.

1 mark — The simile suggests that their attention is **kind but braced for disappointment**, which already adds quiet pressure on her.

Q2. [1] — Air “thinning and going cold”

1 mark — She is **terrified** / suddenly **gripped by stage fright**; her body is experiencing the physical sensations of panic, even though the hall itself has not changed.

Q3. [2] — Effect of short sentences “Not partly. Entirely.”

1 mark — The two very short, blunt sentences slow the pace and create a sense of **absolute, total closure** of the throat.

1 mark — They mimic the **abruptness** of the failure — there is no gradual warning, no near miss; the reader feels the **finality** of the moment exactly as she felt it.

Q4. [2] — Silence that “sharpens”

1 mark — **Sharpens** suggests the silence becomes **more acute, more painful**, almost as though it had an edge that she can feel.

1 mark — “As if the room itself has noticed” personifies the hall; it suggests her **paranoid awareness** that every wall, chair and listener is now focused on her failure.

Q5. [2] — Physical signs of embarrassment

1 mark each for any two of:

- “I felt the heat rise from my collar to the roots of my hair” — blushing.
- She “could not look at” her mother or Mr Tan — averting her eyes.
- She stared at “the line of black tape on the floor” — fixating on a small, safe object.
- She “willed the tape to swallow” her — wishing to disappear.

Q6. [3] — “Carrying me, the way one carries a child across a stream”

1 mark — Identifies the **simile** / comparison and that the choir is **protecting and supporting** her, not blaming her.

1 mark — “**Across a stream**” suggests a moment of **danger or difficulty** that needs help to get through.

1 mark — “**Careful not to wake her**” suggests a **gentleness and tenderness** — the choir do not draw attention to her failure; they sing softly so that she is not further humiliated.

Q7. [2] — “A small and unfussy mercy”

(a) [1]: **Unfussy** suggests the choir helped her **without making a show of it** — quietly, calmly, with no comment or visible drama. It was kindness delivered as though it were ordinary.

(b) [1]: The narrator admits that she had “teased” some of the choir members “in the canteen” and “barely spoken to” others — she had given them **no reason** to be generous to her, and so their kindness is undeserved.

Q8. [2] — Choir “stepped a half-step back”

1 mark — Literally, the choir **lowered their volume** / pulled back from leading the line.

1 mark — Figuratively, they **gave her space and prominence** — having carried the melody for her, they now allowed her voice to take its proper place at the front of the sound.

Q9. [2] — Mother laughing, not crying

1 mark — She had imagined her mother **devastated, disappointed, perhaps in tears** — i.e. she had exaggerated the seriousness of her failure in her own mind.

1 mark — The contrast shows that **the moment had not been as catastrophic as she had felt it to be**; the world had carried on, and so had her family.

Q10. [2] — Failing vs falling

1 mark — **To fail** is to **come apart in public** — to be defeated, exposed, and left alone in the failure.

1 mark — **To fall** is only to **come down for a moment** and **be caught** by others — a stumble, not a collapse; the difference lies in whether one is supported.

Q11. [1] — Tone of final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, grateful, quietly wise, philosophical, tender**. (Reject: **triumphant, bitter**.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Anthems “feel” old but are young

1 mark — Most listeners **assume** anthems have existed for as long as their country has, because they feel ancient and traditional.

1 mark — In reality, most anthems were **written quite recently** — chiefly in the **nineteenth century**, which makes the musical form itself only about two centuries old.

Q13. [1] — Historical movement

1 mark — **Nineteenth-century European romantic nationalism** (accept: romantic nationalism / nineteenth-century nationalism).

Q14. [2] — Anthem makes strangers feel one thing

1 mark — The crowd is made up of **unrelated strangers** who would normally **disagree about everything**.

1 mark — Yet for **ninety seconds** the anthem **unifies their emotions**, producing one shared feeling — a striking and unusual social effect.

Q15. [1] — “Clumsy phrase”

1 mark — The writer suggests that anyone who has **stood in a stadium during a well-sung anthem** knows the feeling **first-hand**, and uses a **shorter and more honest name** for it than the academic term — the writer finds the **lived experience** more accurate than the sociological label. (Accept: he finds “collective emotion” too detached / dry.)

Q16. [2] — Why anthems are uncomfortable

1 mark each for any two of:

- Many lyrics are **violent** — they speak of bloodshed (e.g. France’s “Marseillaise”).
- Many were written as **battle songs** against colonial powers, and the original texts still call for the spilling of blood.
- Some were composed **during colonial periods** and contain assumptions about **empire and racial hierarchy** that modern citizens find painful.

Q17. [2] — Sport as a substitute for war

1 mark — Where nations once met to **fight each other physically**, they now meet to **compete in sport**.

1 mark — The ritual of playing both anthems before the match preserves the **seriousness and rivalry** of those older confrontations, but in a **peaceful, symbolic** form — sport now performs the work that war once did.

Q18. [2] — Why regional anthems fail

1 mark — Such proposals fail because the emotion an anthem produces is **not really about the world** or about large regional blocs.

1 mark — It is about the **specific country** in which one was **born or chose to settle** — i.e. anthems work only because they are **small and local**, not global.

Q19. [2] — Anthem as “last remaining” public chorus

1 mark — Communal singing — in churches, schools and workplaces — has **largely disappeared** from modern life.

1 mark — The anthem is therefore one of the **few remaining** opportunities for citizens to **raise their voices together** — abolishing it would **remove a rare, democratic, shared form of expression** without putting anything in its place.

Q20. [2] — “Waiting, like the music, for its cue”

1 mark — The image is **neatly musical** — it draws together the article’s central subject (anthems) with its central claim (the desire to belong has not disappeared).

1 mark — It is **quietly optimistic**: the desire is not dead, merely **paused**, ready to return whenever a piece of music gives it permission — a thoughtful and memorable closing note.

Q21. [1] — Writer’s overall attitude

1 mark — **Measured / balanced / cautiously sympathetic / quietly defensive**. The writer expects anthems to **evolve rather than disappear**, and views their persistence as **more interesting than embarrassing**. (Reject: **dismissive, hostile**.)

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points ($\frac{1}{2}$ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

What anthems actually do (Paragraphs 2 and 4):

1. They take **unrelated strangers** who normally disagree and make them **feel one shared emotion** for a short time.
2. They prompt **physical, almost reverent responses** — hand on chest, raised eyes, joining in.
3. They are most often heard at **international sporting events**, where they are played before both teams.
4. They act as a **peaceful substitute** for the older, **bloodier confrontations** between nations.

Criticisms now made of anthems (Paragraphs 3 and 5):

5. Lyrics are often **violent** — speaking of bloodshed and battle (e.g. the Marseillaise).
6. Many anthems contain **colonial assumptions** or **racial hierarchies** that modern citizens find painful to sing.
7. They feel **out of date** in a **globalised world** where people, work and trade cross borders freely.
8. Proposals for **regional or global anthems** have not succeeded — anthems remain stubbornly tied to a **single nation**.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

When played at the right moment, a national anthem briefly unites a crowd of unrelated strangers, producing a shared emotion expressed through raised eyes, hands on chests, and joining

voices. It is mostly heard before international sporting fixtures, replacing the older, bloodier rivalries between nations. Critics, however, object that many lyrics are violent or carry colonial and racial assumptions, and that insisting on a single nation's music feels backward in a globalised world that crosses borders freely.

Length count: 78 words from “When” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —